

will send a refund check in the mail to cover the surplus, usually within a week or two of closing.

Can the seller bail on our agreed price if the appraisal comes in much higher than I offered in the contract?

Definitely not. In the rare event that the appraisal comes in higher than the purchase price, the seller is contractually obligated to sell the house to you at the agreed-upon price, no matter what the appraisal says. They would be in breach of contract if they refuse to sell, and you may be able to sue for specific performance, which forces them to sell the house to you at that price. Plus, if they don't sell it to you, they can't go under contract with anyone else until your contract has ended—which you won't allow if you're trying to get the house.

The previous owner changed something they weren't supposed to change (like taking shelves down and leaving a giant hole in the wall). Is this allowed?

Nope, unless otherwise specified in the contract. Removing anything that was attached is changing the home from the condition in which you saw it. If you notice something like this during your final walk-through, don't close until there is a satisfactory resolution. If this happens *after* your final walk-through (which would be unlikely and very sneaky on the seller's part), you can pursue legal action—or just choose to let it go. Some people are just bad apples.

When do I get the keys?

You know how all your friends take a picture when they get their first set of keys? (Does the front of this book ring any bells?)

Most often, you'll get your house keys at closing, so long as your closing date and possession date are the same. You'll find all these deadlines in your offer contract. If the possession date isn't the same as the closing date, you will want to ask your agent when and where you can pick up the keys.

So, does my house come with lightbulbs?